

**TU Dortmund University**  
**Action Plan**  
**to Reform Research Assessment**  
**2025**

In accordance with the  
Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment



## Profile of TU Dortmund University

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TU Dortmund University is a young and dynamic university with a special, internationally visible **profile** thanks to its lively combination of strong natural sciences and engineering as well as social sciences and humanities. It offers an **outstanding environment** for cutting-edge research in basic and applied fields as well as excellent conditions for successful studies. Its close ties to a region undergoing structural change make TU Dortmund University an expert in accompanying and shaping economic, social and political **transformation processes** and finding answers to the big questions of the future.

Five strong **profile areas** currently shape research at TU Dortmund University:

- (1) From Elementary Particles to Products Along Value Added Networks,
- (2) Innovations for sustainability and health,
- (3) Data, Models and Simulations to Shape Our Future,
- (4) Educational and Labor Worlds of Tomorrow and
- (5) Society and Transformational Processes in the 21st Century.

In line with its educational **mission** across the board and for the region, the university offers around 30,000 students from Germany and abroad a diverse range of subjects, including comprehensive teacher training. As a **campus university**, TU Dortmund University also develops its special character in the social interaction of students, staff and researchers from over 130 nations.

The location in the **metropolitan and scientific region of the Ruhr Area** opens up access to exceptionally attractive research, teaching and transfer networks. This includes cooperation opportunities within the University Alliance Ruhr (UA Ruhr) including the Research Alliance Ruhr, the proximity to around 20 other universities, universities of applied sciences and non-university research institutions as well as the proximity to the TechnologieZentrumDortmund. Thanks to a modern understanding of research, an effective intertwining of fundamentals, application and transfer takes place, making TU Dortmund University a decisive **driver of innovation** for the region and a synergy generator for a strong start-up scene.

## Research Assessment at TU Dortmund University

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Due to the broad spectrum of disciplines/subjects at TU Dortmund University, organized in 17 departments the types of research output are rather diverse: they range from publications of various kinds to software, from research data and patents to works of art. This diversity must be taken into account when evaluating research performance. TU Dortmund University recognizes the necessity to adapt criteria and processes of research assessment to the changing of research and its achievements.

This process is initiated and supervised by the Rectorate of TU Dortmund University, coordinated by a small task force and conducted by representatives of all stakeholders (both research and administration). The challenges and actions depicted in the following 10-point Action Plan respond to this line. The action plan will be refined and further developed in the dialogue between Rectorate, administration and researchers in order to improve research assessment.

In the process of reforming research assessment, the collaboration in the UA Ruhr is a chance to exchange experiences of good practice and to improve processes where needed.

## 10 Commitments to Reform Research Assessment

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### Commitment #1

**Recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research**

#### Actions

At TU Dortmund University, we actively recognize the diversity of contributions and career paths in research by integrating inclusive and flexible recruitment practices. Our evaluation process in the recruitment of professorial and scientific staff does not focus on metrics but instead values individual contributions while taking career breaks into account (cp. commitment #3). Job advertisements welcome candidates with varied backgrounds, including those with non-linear career trajectories or experience beyond academia.

To ensure fair and comprehensive assessments, our hiring process for professor appointments relies on peer review in combination with hiring committees that are diverse in discipline, career stage, and background. We maintain transparency in our selection criteria, recognizing achievements in research, leadership, teaching, public engagement, and collaborative or non-academic research. Key documents outlining the procedure of an appointment process are publicly available. Additionally, we encourage targeted recruitment initiatives and use special formats like Open Rank tenders or Tenure Track positions.

Through these measures, we foster an environment where all research contributions are valued, ensuring that excellence in science is recognized in its many forms.

## Commitment #2

**Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators**

### **Actions**

TU Dortmund University actively endeavors to focus internal evaluation processes even more strongly on qualitative assessment. Peer review forms the basis of the appointment process of professors at TU Dortmund University. Furthermore, peer review procedures are being implemented in all research evaluation processes.

In internal funding programs, the focus is already on qualitative criteria, selection criteria are as broad as possible. For example, narrative CVs (DFG template) are used in internal research funding.

## Commitment #3

**Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index**

### **Challenges**

*Whilst the appointment platform for professorship already offers the possibility to indicate periods of time out of academic career, applicants must use this chance. Additionally, the appointment processes have yet to be rolled out to academic staff at lower levels than professors. As those application processes are not managed via the existing tool but are rather in charge of the departments assisted by the central administration, standardization of this processes is still a challenge to be met.*

### **Actions**

In appointment procedures for professorships, various criteria are already consistently taken into account. For example, the prototype for a CV provided in the application platform for professors offers the option to indicate periods of time out of the academic career in order to be able to take academic age into account. The appointment management unit of TU Dortmund University provides model criteria for appointment committees; e. g. the h-index of applicants or the journal impact factor of their publications are not a selection criterion at all in vocations of professorships. The appointment committee is reminded of the responsible use of metrics.

The University Library already offers support for both researchers, appointment committees and administration with its bibliometric advice center. In addition to providing advice on the possibilities and limitations of the licensed tools, the University Library also carries out analyses. It is increasingly focusing on open databases such as OpenAlex instead of

commercial databases in order to guarantee transparency and not to depend on commercial providers. This will be expanded in the future, e. g. a handout for the responsible use of metrics is to be created.

#### **Commitment #4**

**Avoid the use of rankings of research organizations in research assessment**

#### **Challenges**

*Although TU Dortmund University does not use rankings to assess individual research achievements, it cannot be denied that rankings play a role in the rhetoric of research and in the visibility of institutions and thus in the attraction of students and academic staff. TU Dortmund University therefore suggests that this point, which is likely to affect other research institutions as well, should be further discussed and elaborated.*

#### **Actions**

TU Dortmund University recognizes that university rankings are commonly based on broad, institution-wide indicators that do not accurately reflect the quality or impact of individual researchers' contributions. While we monitor rankings to understand external and international perceptions of our institution and are aware of their relevance in getting the attention of international researchers as well as attracting international students, we do not use them as a criterion in appointment or negotiation procedures, hiring, or funding decisions. Instead, we are committed to a fair and comprehensive assessment that values individual research contributions.

#### **Commitment #5**

**Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organizational changes committed to**

#### **Challenges**

*TU Dortmund University recognizes the necessity to train staff to become multipliers in supporting the implementation of CoARA by its researchers and administration. For this purpose, it would be very helpful, if National Chapters or even CoARA itself offer training material and strengthen networking and knowledge exchange.*

## **Actions**

While research assessment and its evaluation are part of the daily work both in science and in administration, the reforming of research assessment according to CoARA needs to be coordinated. This will be carried out by a small task force in order to make the process as efficient as possible. This task force will give guidance about implementation of research assessment criteria in order to enable administration and researchers to adapt those criteria in research assessment processes they are involved in. The exchange of good practice is addressed in commitment #8. In the long-term resources will only be needed for engagement in CoARA working groups and the National Chapter.

### **Commitment #6**

**Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes**

## **Actions**

TU Dortmund University aims at adopting the CV scheme offered by the German Research Foundation (DFG) for appointment procedures not only in the appointment process for professorships but rather at all career stages. In this context the use of the existing application templates will be evaluated and adjusted if necessary.

### **Commitment #7**

**Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use**

## **Actions**

TU Dortmund University's communication channels are used to transparently inform the research community about the evaluation processes and the implementation of planned actions within CoARA

Good practices for evaluating research groups, departments, are gathered by the small task force coordinating the implementation of CoARA's commitments at TU Dortmund University and will be made available to both researchers and administration. A pilot information session will be organized.

The university's graduate center (<https://graduierzenzentrum.tu-dortmund.de/en/graduate-center/>) already offers a broad range of workshops and counselling services to doctoral and postdoctoral researchers dealing with various aspects of the agreement on the reforming of research assessment (e. g. good scientific practice, career planning). Furthermore, the university's Office of Research Support Services will offer workshops and resources to inform and raise awareness among faculty and staff on new evaluation practices and criteria, esp. in funding programs.

### **Commitment #8**

#### **Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition**

##### ***Challenges***

*The diversity of the three UA Ruhr universities in their organization means that the processes at the individual universities are highly heterogeneous; however, dialogue with one another promotes reflection and continuous evaluation of the processes at each university.*

##### **Actions**

TU Dortmund University is part of the University Alliance Ruhr (UA Ruhr) which has also joined CoARA as an alliance. The administrative and service organizations of the UA Ruhr are already exchanging good practices on processes in the administration of research support in general (e. g. open access, bibliometrics, but also funding criteria). The CoARA task forces of the UA Ruhr universities exchange information on the implementation of CoARA. Joint funding programs of the UA Ruhr will be evaluated in terms of their funding criteria. The action plans of the individual universities will be coordinated with the action plan of the UA Ruhr as an alliance.

Furthermore, TU Dortmund University participates in the National Chapter of Germany.

As research assessment is discussed in various national organizations and committees TU Dortmund University will raise awareness for this topic amongst its members to enable them to actively take part in discussions about reforming research assessment in their individual networks or working groups.

### **Commitment #9**

#### **Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the commitments**

##### **Actions**

According to the development of its research strategy, TU Dortmund University will provide a separate website on which progress in the reform process will be documented. The action plan, which is designed as a living document, will also be linked and made persistently available via Zenodo.

### **Commitment #10**

**Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and re-search**

#### **Actions**

TU Dortmund University generally evaluates programs every two years (unless otherwise required). It has several established and systematic feedback tools and processes that can be applied according to the needs. This includes, amongst others, regular surveys of researchers. These processes generally review the effectiveness and efficiency of the measures and actions applied. Regular feedback opportunities by involved groups and informed members of the university allow targeted adjustments and deploy resources effectively.

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